

# Ethics vs Law vs Compliance

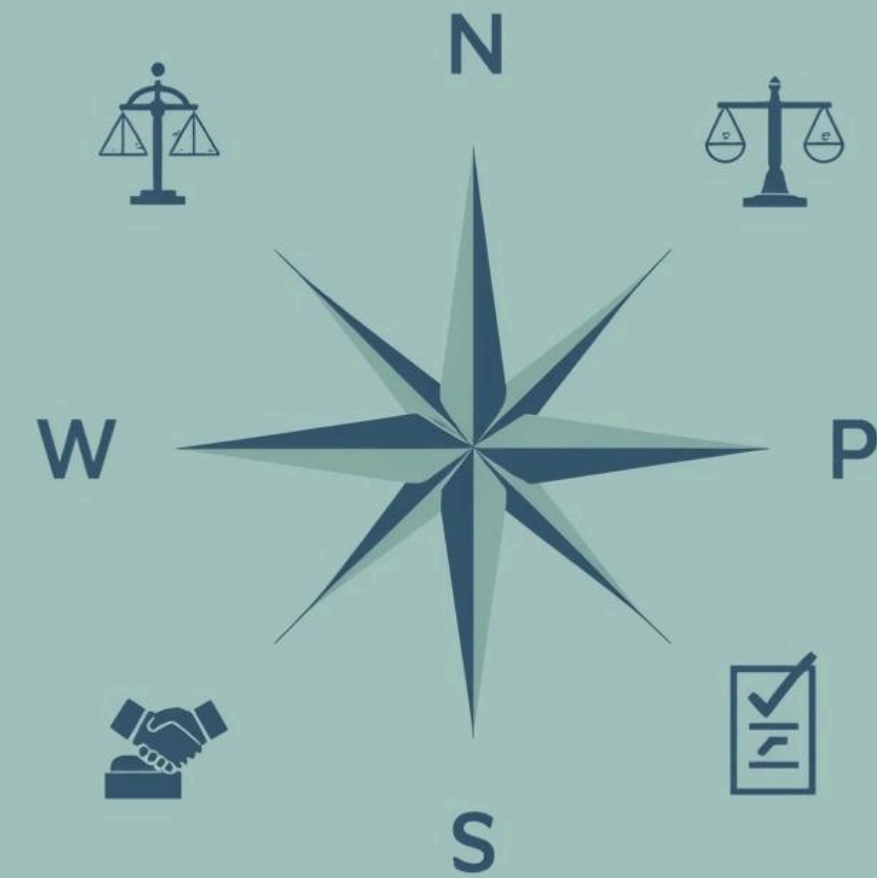


A system can be legal,  
fully compliant, and still  
be deeply **unethical**.

AI exposes this gap more  
clearly than almost any  
other technology



- AI evolves faster than law
- Regulation is reactive
- Ethical harm often appears before legal frameworks exist



# What is Ethics?

- Ethics asks: What should we do?
- Concerned with:
  - Values
  - Harm
  - Rights
  - Fairness
  - Human dignity



# What is Law

- Law defines minimum acceptable behavior
- Enforceable by the state
- Jurisdiction-specific
- Often lags behind technology

## Critical point

- Law reacts to harm
- Law cannot anticipate every ethical risk





# What is Compliance?

- Compliance is organizational adherence to laws and regulations
- Emphasizes:
  - Checklists
  - Documentation
  - Controls
  - Risk avoidance

## Important distinction

- Compliance is procedural, not moral
- It asks: Are we allowed to do this?



# Comparison



## Ethics

What should be done  
Sets direction



## Law

What must be done  
Sets boundaries



## Compliance

What is required to avoid  
fines  
Ensures adherence



# Legal but Unethical

- Facial recognition deployed legally but without consent
- Employee monitoring tools that invade privacy
- Algorithmic scoring that is lawful but discriminatory





# “Compliance Only Thinking”

- “If it’s legal, it’s fine” thinking
- Ethics reduced to box-ticking
- Responsibility outsourced to regulation



# Key Questions

- Should we do this?
- Who could be harmed?
- Who benefits?
- Who bears the risk?
- Can this decision be justified publicly?

